



Let us look at the final phase of National Movement and try to understand the situations that led to the partition of India. The people of the country faced very difficult questions and had to accept very difficult answers in these years.

14.1 Should the War be supported by Indians? 1939-42

You have read about the Second World War already. When the war started in 1939, most of the provinces of India were governed by Congress ministries. The British government had agreed to give the Indians the right to rule themselves to some extent. The British parliament passed the Government of India Act in 1935. According to this, provinces could hold elections and winning parties could form governments. However, the right to vote was given to a small section of the population – only about 12 % for provincial assemblies and about 1 % for the Central assembly. When elections were held in the assemblies of the 11 provinces of British India in 1937, Congress won in most provinces. Eight out of 11 provinces had a Congress “Prime Minister”, working under the supervision of a British Governor.

The world war was going on. Congress leaders were now facing a difficult situation. Should they help the British in fighting the war against Germany, Japan, Italy and other Axis forces? Britain had decided that India will participate in the war without even asking them. There were reasons both for and against supporting the war.

The Congress was divided on this issue. Most Congress leaders were opposed to Hitler, Mussolini and the ideology of fascism. They wanted to fight against the Fascist drive to conquer other sovereign nations. The Congress expected that the British would see their double standards in the expectation that India should support them in fighting the fascists but not giving (or at least promising) India full freedom. The British realised this but, at the same time, it was hard for them to accept that they will really have to dismantle the empire they had built.



- Do you think Indians should have felt grateful to the British government for the powers given by the Act of 1935?
- Do you think the rise of Hitler was such a big threat to the freedom of humanity that Indians should have set aside their fight for freedom from the British and concentrated on the fight for a free world?
- According to you, what would be the reasons for and against supporting the British in the World War II?

LETTER TO ADOLF HITLER

HERR HITLER

BERLIN

GERMANY

DEAR FRIEND,

Friends have been urging me to write to you for the sake of humanity. But I have resisted their request, because of the feeling that any letter from me would be an impertinence. Something tells me that I must not calculate and that I must make my appeal for whatever it may be worth.

It is quite clear that you are today the one person in the world who can prevent a war which may reduce humanity to the savage state.

Must you pay that price for an object however worthy it may appear to you to be? Will you listen to the appeal of one who has deliberately shunned the method of war not without considerable success?

Anyway I anticipate your forgiveness, if I have erred in writing to you.

I remain,

Your sincere friend,

M. K. GANDHI

Source: The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi,
Vol. 76 : 31 May, 1939 - 15 October, 1939.

There were different political parties in Britain. At the time of the War, Britain had an all-party government headed by Prime Minister Winston Churchill of the Conservative party. The Conservatives wanted to maintain the empire for as long as possible. In comparison to the Conservatives, the Labour party was more willing to help Indians get their freedom.

The British were willing to give the status of Dominion to India under the British Crown soon after the War. But the Congress wanted a promise of complete freedom for India. The Congress also demanded that an immediate national government should be set up at the Centre. The British objected to this by saying that they have to also protect the interests of several other communities in India. They meant that Congress did not represent all

Indians, (like Muslims). They also implied that Congress may be ignoring the interests of many Indians. So, the British were required to protect these interests.



Fig 14.1 : Crossing Irawady river in 1945,
Royal Indian Army



Fig 14.2 : Elephants Loading Supplies in C-46
Planes during Second World War in India

The Congress was upset that the British refused to promise freedom to India and decided to walk out of the provincial governments. All the Congress ministries who had come to power in 1937 resigned in October 1939.

The government had got special war time powers to maintain law and order to be able to focus on winning the war. Anyone who opposed the government could be jailed immediately and kept in prison for a long time without going to court. People were not given the freedom of speech. Through 1940 and 1941, the Congress organised a series of individual satyagrahas to pressurise the British to promise freedom once the war had ended. No major mass protest was launched at this time.



Do you think the Congress could have taken some other steps to protest against the attitude of the British?

- Why did the British not make the promise and win the support of the Indians? After all, in 1939, only a promise was being asked for? Discuss together in class.
- When ministers resign, who continues to conduct the day to day affairs of governance?
- Imagine what would happen if Congress leaders increased their protests against the British government at this point of time? Would it make the fight for freedom stronger?

14.2 Who represents the people of the country?

Now that the Indian people were revolting against the British rule, they were upset. They looked for ways to punish the Congress and make it weak and unpopular among the people. The British started questioning the right of the Congress to represent the people of the country. Now, they followed the 'Divide and Rule Policy' more vigorously.

To achieve this, the British government supported and encouraged the plans of the Muslim League and gave little importance to the Congress. In this period, the Muslim League and its leaders like M. A. Jinnah became more active in mass politics.

14.2.1 The Muslim League

Muslim League was formed in 1906. Till the 1930s, it mainly represented the interests of Muslim landlords of UP and did not have much mass support. It had demanded that the British should create separate seats in all councils for which only Muslims would vote. It had argued that since the majority people in many areas were Hindus, there were more chances of Hindus getting elected to councils. If this happened, Muslims would not be able to protect their interests in the government. But, if a certain number of seats were reserved for Muslims for which only the Muslim population of an area would vote, these Muslim members would be able to raise the concerns and problems of Muslims. The Congress had accepted this logic and separate electorates were implemented from 1909. When provincial governments were elected in 1937, the League won 102 of the 482 Muslim seats in the country.

However, the Congress also fought elections on the Muslim seats because it believed that it was a national party and not a party of only Hindus. The Congress won 26 out of the 58 Muslim seats it had contested.

In 1937, the Muslim League got only 4.4 percent of the total Muslim votes in



- Discuss the importance of addressing the concerns of minorities. Why is it felt that majority based elections are not enough to help minorities?
- Separate electorate was one method to protect minority interests. Can you think of some other methods that can be helpful for this purpose? For example, would it help if there was a rule that a non Muslim member of a council must consult the Muslim population of his/ her constituency before voting on an issue that concerned them? When would such a method work and under what conditions would it fail to be effective?

the elections. The Muslim League was popular in the United Provinces, Bombay and Madras. However, it was quite weak in the three provinces from which Pakistan was to be made just ten years later, that is, Bengal, the North-West Frontier Province (now in Pakistan) and Punjab. Even in Sind, it failed to form a government. But the situation changed in the next 10 years. In 1946, when elections were held again for the provincial and central assemblies, the League succeeded in winning the Muslim seats.

What happened to the Muslim population in the years between 1937 and 1947? The League pointed out many issues. It blamed that Congress was insensitive to the needs of Muslims. For example, the Congress refused to form a coalition government with the Muslim League in the United Provinces where it too had won many seats. The Congress had banned its members from taking membership of the Muslim League. Congress members could be members of the Hindu Mahasabha before. But this was also banned from 1938, only after objections from Muslim Congressmen like Maulana Azad. Thus, the League created the impression that Congress was basically a Hindu party and did not want to share power with the Muslims.

14.2.2 The Hindu Mahasabha and the RSS

During this period, the Hindu Mahasabha and the Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh (RSS), a national cultural organisation were mobilizing the Hindus. These organisations wished to unite all the Hindus and overcome the divisions of caste and sect to reform their social life. They also gave out the message that India was the land of the Hindus who were in a majority. Many Congressmen were also impressed with the activities of these organisations.

Congress tried very hard to create a secular understanding among its members. It also tried to connect with the Muslim masses and make them feel secure. They

wanted to change the wrong impression that was being created in their minds by the messages and activities of organisations like the Muslim League, the Hindu Mahasabha and the RSS. Congress argued that Hindus and Muslims were not people of two different nations, but part and parcel of one Indian nation. However, the British were eagerly listening to the fears of the League about Hindu domination and suggesting ways to make the Muslims secure.

14.3 The “Pakistan” Resolution

Many people now felt that the separate governing arrangements were needed for regions where Muslims were in majority. For example, the Urdu poet Mohammad Iqbal, the writer of the song “*Sare Jahan Se Achha Hindustan Hamara*”, spoke of a need for a “North- West Indian Muslim state” in his presidential address to the Muslim League in 1930.

The name Pakistan or Pak-stan (from Punjab, Afghan, Kashmir, Sind and Baluchistan) was coined by a Punjabi Muslim student at Cambridge, Choudhry Rehmat Ali. This young student wrote pamphlets between 1933 and 1935. He desired a separate national status for this new entity. No one took Rehmat Ali seriously in the 1930s, especially the League and other Muslim leaders who dismissed his idea merely as a student’s dream.

The political situation in India changed when British started following the policy of ‘Divide and Rule’ and Congress failed to address the fears of Muslims. On 23 March



Dr BR Ambedkar, Pakistan or the Partition of India “Introduction” 1940

It is beyond question that Pakistan is a scheme which will have to be taken into account. The Muslims will insist upon the scheme being considered... The British cannot consent to settle power upon an aggressive Hindu majority and make it its heir, leaving it to deal with the minorities at its sweet pleasure. That would not be ending imperialism. It would be creating another imperialism.

1940, the Muslim League moved a resolution and demanded autonomy for the parts of the subcontinent where Muslim were in majority. This ambiguous resolution never mentioned partition or Pakistan. However, in later years, it became known as the Pakistan resolution. People were thinking of different ways to solve the issues raised by the League and a new nation state of Pakistan was one among these alternatives. But since the discussions and negotiations were not working out, the idea of a separate nation state of Pakistan became stronger. The Congress was unable to fulfill the demands of M A Jinnah, leader of the Muslim League.

From 1940 to 1946, the League convinced Muslim masses about the benefits and need for a separate nation. Peasants could imagine a state where Hindu zamindars and moneylenders did not exploit them. Traders, businessmen and job seekers could think of a state where competition from Hindu traders, businessmen and job seekers would not be there. There would be greater religious freedom. There would be freedom for the Muslim elite to run the government the way they wanted.



How would people assess the possible benefits from the politics of Muslim League? Would they have any doubts? What kind of questions would they have? Discuss.

From 1942 to 1945, most Congress leaders were in jail. The League made use of the time to build its base among the people.

14.4 Who Will Make the British Quit India?

By 1941, Japan had started expanding into South East Asia. This was clear threat to Indian territories as well. The British wanted Indian people to support it in the war against Japan. In March 1942, Prime Minister Churchill was persuaded to send one of his ministers, Sir Stafford Cripps, to India to try and make a compromise with Gandhi and the Congress. But these talks failed after the Congress insisted that the Viceroy should first appoint an Indian as the Defence Member of his Executive Council.

After the failure of the Cripps Mission, Mahatma Gandhi decided to launch his third major movement against the British rule. This was the “Quit India” campaign. This campaign began in August 1942. Although Gandhi was sent to jail, other younger activists organised strikes and acts of sabotage all over the country. The young men and women left their colleges to go to jail in very large numbers. Socialist members of the Congress, such as Jayaprakash Narayan, were particularly active in the underground resistance movement. In several districts, such as Satara in the west and Medinipur in the east, “independent” governments were declared. The British responded with a lot of force, yet it took them more than a year to suppress this rebellion.

The Communist Party of India, in the meanwhile, decided to support the British war effort. It was alarmed at the attack on the Soviet Union by the Nazis. It realised the danger at a world level and called the war a People’s War. On the contrary, Gandhi felt that Indians would be able to handle Japan on their own after the British leave India.

The initial victories of Japan against the Americans and Europeans created a strong impression on the people in India. Firstly, it seemed that the European colonialists would get defeated very soon. Secondly, Japan was an Asian country and could stand up against the European colonialists. Indians felt that they too can stand up and fight against Britain decisively. The myth that the British race was superior than others was destroyed in the minds of people.

Subhash Chandra Bose wanted to take up the opportunity created by the difficulties of the British. He said that India’s independence was of utmost importance and we should take the help of the Japanese to throw out the British. He went secretly to Germany and Japan and collected an army of Indian soldiers in 1942.

Who were these soldiers? In the beginning, these Indian soldiers were in the British army. They had been captured by the Japanese when the British were defeated in Burma and Malaya. They were POWs (prisoners of war). Bose recruited them in his army which he called the Indian National Army (INA). Later, other Indians also joined the army including many women. However, Gandhi did not agree with the plans of Bose. He felt that the Japanese cannot be the liberators of India. But Subhash continued in his chosen path and led an army of Indian soldiers to fight along with the Imperial Army of Japan against the British for almost three years.

This time was very dramatic and difficult for the entire world. At one point, it had seemed that the Allied powers were losing the war. But Russia stopped the Nazi forces with the victory in Stalingrad. The Allied powers regained control and eventually won the Second World War. Subhash Bose's INA was defeated by the British army. After this, it is not certain whether Bose disappeared or died.

In June 1944, when the war was about to end, the British government released Gandhi from prison. They set the time for another round of negotiations and talks for Indian independence.



Fig 14.3 : Subhash Chandra Bose



- Why did the Japanese allow Bose to recruit soldiers whom they had imprisoned?
- Why did the Indian soldiers join INA?
- Why were Indian soldiers not scared of losing the war and falling into the hands of the British? What would the British do to them?



Review the period between 1942-45. How can you say that the resistance of Indian people to the British rule had become more powerful than ever before?

14.4.1 The popular Upsurge -1946-48

The soldiers of INA were imprisoned and the British decided to punish them. A trial of INA soldiers was begun. The British decided to court martial them for being traitors to the army and hanging them to death in punishment.

There was unrest, unhappiness and discontent in different parts of India when the INA trials started. The issue of Hindu- Muslim

identity and separatist politics often became unimportant during such times. For example, many of the INA soldiers who were being tried for treason were Muslims, yet the people's anger and sympathy gave no thought to the religion of the soldiers.



- Imagine the tragic turn of events and how these must have affected the lives of these people?
- What horror would the other Indians have felt at the thought that the INA soldiers who were like heroes to them were being tried and hanged as traitors by the British?

If you imagine yourself in the years after the War ended, it will be easy to understand the situation in the country. People were restless because of food shortages, rationing of food, high prices, black marketeering and hoarding. Workers were angry about low wages. Railway, postal employees and other government employees were planning to go on India wide strike against prices.

On 18th February 1946, the guards or Ratings of the Royal Indian Navy in Bombay harbour went on hunger strike to protest against bad food and behaviour of their British officers. The strike rapidly spread to other naval men on the Bombay shore and all the naval bases in India. The navy men put up the tricolour, the crescent and the hammer and sickle flags jointly on the mast of the ship. A Naval Central Strike committee was elected with M S Khan as its head. The strike committee demanded better food, equal pay for white and Indian sailors. They also demanded for the release of INA and other political prisoners and withdrawal of Indian troops from Indonesia.



Fig 14.4 : Memorial for the Naval guards who revolted for India's freedom in 1946

78 ships, 20 shore establishments, and 20,000 Ratings took part in the strike. Hundreds of students, both Hindus and Muslims, came out on the streets of Bombay to support them. They also clashed with the police and the army. On February 22, 3 lakh mill workers put down their tools in Bombay and fought violently for 2 days on the streets with the police and the army.

The year 1946 was a year of strikes and work stoppages in factories and mills in many parts of the country. CPI and the Socialist parties were active in these movements. The countryside was also on the boil.

An agitation was started in Bengal by small and poor peasants who took land of the bigger landowners to cultivate. They demanded that their share of harvest should be increased to two portions out of three instead of half or even less. This was eventually given to them at that time. This was called the *Tebhaga* movement and was led by the Provincial Kisan Sabha.

In Hyderabad, the Communist party led a massive movement of farmers of the Telangana region. The Telangana farmers opposed the large land owners and demanded that debts of farmers be cancelled. They also demanded that bonded labour should be stopped and land be distributed to those who worked on it. The peasants took up arms to fight against the rulers and their armies. Almost 3000 villages were part of the movement. Another armed revolt of peasants took place in Travancore (Kerala) in Punnappra-Vayalar.



Review the actions of ordinary masses in the country. What were they demanding?

- It was noted that religious divisions were not important in many of these mass movements mentioned above. What could be the reason for the unity of the people in these movements?

14.5 Muslim League and Congress - Negotiation for transfer of power

When political negotiations between top leaders began again in 1945, the British agreed to create an entirely Indian central Executive Council, except for the Viceroy and the Commander-in-Chief of the armed forces. They did this as a first step towards full independence. Discussions about the transfer of power failed due to Jinnah's demand that the League should have an absolute right to choose all the Muslim members of the Executive Council. This demand was not acceptable to others. Most nationalist Muslims supported the Congress Party. The Unionist Party of Punjab, which had a large number of Muslim members, did not agree with Muslim League's demand. In fact, Maulana Azad was the leader of the Congress Party delegation for these discussions as he was the President of this party!

In 1946, elections were held for the Provincial Governments. The Muslim League won all 30 reserved constituencies in the Centre and 442 out of 509 seats in the provinces. The League was able to establish itself as the dominant party among Muslim voters only around 1946. It wanted to represent itself as the "sole spokesperson" of India's Muslims. It had got more than 86% of the Muslim votes. In 1946, the Congress swept the general constituencies, capturing over 91 per cent of the non-Muslim vote.



What were the demands of the Muslim League that were not acceptable to the Congress? Do you agree with the reasons of the Congress?

- According to you, what did the election results of 1946 indicate about public mood?

14.6 A possible alternative to Partition

In March 1946, the British Cabinet sent a three member mission team to Delhi to examine the demand made by the League and suggest a suitable political framework for Indian freedom. This Cabinet Mission toured the country for three months and recommended a three-tier confederation but India was to remain united. Initially, all the major parties accepted this plan. But the agreement was short-lived because the parties had different opinions of the plan.

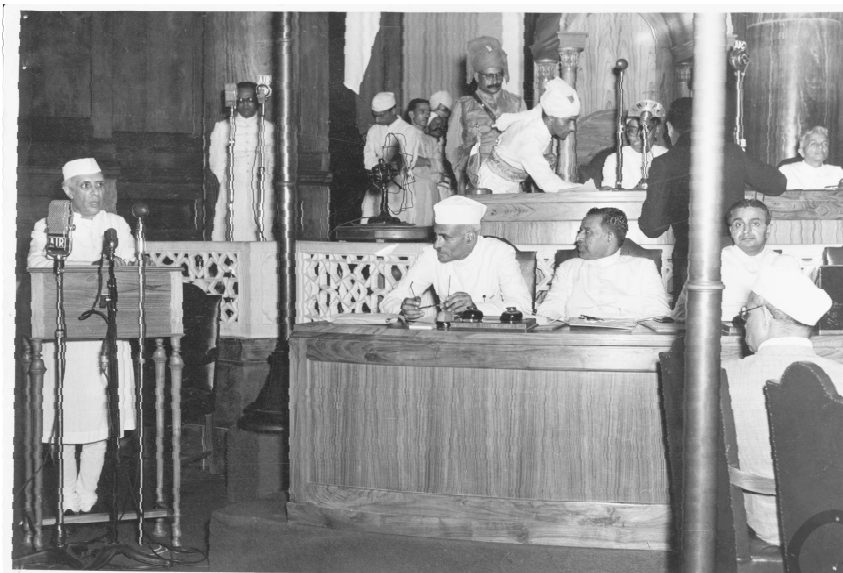


Fig 14.5 : Jawaharlal Nehru at Independence declaration

Ultimately, neither the League nor the Congress agreed to the Cabinet Mission's proposal.

The Muslim League decided that its demands cannot be met through discussions and it must ask the people to come out on the streets. It decided on "Direct Action" to win its demand for Pakistan and announced

16 August 1946 as "Direct Action Day". On this day, riots started in Calcutta. These riots lasted for several days and several thousand people died in the riots. By March 1947, violence spread to many parts of northern India.

Because of the mass violence, the Congress agreed for dividing the Punjab into two halves in March 1947. One half was to be with Muslim majority and the other with Hindu/ Sikh majority. Congress also agreed for a similar division in Bengal.

In February 1947, Mountbatten replaced Wavell and became the Viceroy. Mountbatten started one last round of talks to find a solution. When these talks also failed, he announced that British India would become freed but also would be divided. Muslim majority areas of Punjab, NWFP, Sind, Baluchistan and East Bengal would be made part of a new state of Pakistan. The formal transfer of power from British Government to Pakistan would be done on 14th and to India, it would be done on the 15th of August, 1947. This solution was the only workable solution to end the year of riots, bloodshed and hatred that people were filled with.

14.6.1 Partition and migrations

Now that a Muslim nation, Pakistan, was created, a painful and unimaginable situation arose for many people. Most Hindus living on Pakistani side of the border felt insecure and forced to leave their homes. So did many Muslims, living on the other side of this border. Not all the people wanted this, not all the people understood why this was happening. They felt anger and hatred against each other for being forced to move out of their homes, villages and cities. Around 1.5 crore people, both Hindus and Muslims, were displaced.



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CALCUTTA, FRIDAY, AUGUST 15, 1947.

TWO ANNAS.

TWO DOMINIONS ARE BORN

Political Freedom For One-Fifth Of Human Race



RE Sir Frederick Burrows talking to Mr. S. C. Roy Chowdhury, Mayor of Calcutta, at New Delhi while waiting for his arrival at Mr. C. Rajagopalachari, Chief Minister of West Bengal, at Government House, Calcutta.

Close Friendship with Britain

Nehru's Reply to Mr. Attlee

NEW DELHI, Aug. 15.—My colleagues in the U.K. Government join with me in sending, on this historic day, greetings and good wishes to the Government and people of India, says a message from Mr. Attlee to Pandit Nehru. He adds: "It is our earnest wish that India may go forward in its unity and prosperity and in its contribution to the peace and prosperity of the world."

Pandit Nehru replied: "On behalf of the people of India, I want to express my grateful thanks for your message of greeting on this historic day when India emerges into freedom. That freedom means much to us, but it also means much to Asia and the world. We hope to utilize that freedom for the advancement of the peace and prosperity of the world. In these great tasks we shall look forward to the closest cooperation with your Government."—AP.

VIRAJANT MOUNTBATTEN
AWARDED EARLDOM
LONDON, Aug. 14.—Viscount Mountbatten, Governor-General of India, was today awarded an Earldom.—REUTERS

Gandhi & Subhaschandra to Fast and Pray Today

Meeting Listens to Mahatma Without Interruption

By a Staff Reporter
MR Gandhi will celebrate Independence Day today, by observing a 24-hour fast and spinning and holding special prayer. At his prayer meeting last evening he invited the people to observe the day in a similar manner.

Mr. H. S. Suhrawardy and Mr. S. M. Khan, ex-Minister and Secretary, Calcutta District Muslim League, will fast with Mr. Gandhi.

Mr. Gandhi and Mr. Suhrawardy spent the second day of their joint fast at their residence in Calcutta yesterday.

In contrast to the hostile demonstrations of Wednesday, their residence became a place of pilgrimage for thousands of people yesterday. A large number of them were women. Both Hindus and Muslims came in a peaceful stream from different parts of the city and the suburbs.

Later, Mr. Suhrawardy also addressed a gathering. At the conclusion of his address and after the dismissal of the delegates, a large number of people gathered in front of the residence of Mr. S. M. Khan, and a large number of people gathered in front of the residence of Mr. S. M. Khan.

CALCUTTA WEATHER
Rainfall for the 24-hour period ending 8 P.M. yesterday: 6.44 inches. Maximum temperature: 84° F. Minimum temperature: 72° F. Humidity: 72%.

POWER ASSUMED BY INDIANS

Constituent Assembly Members Take The Oath

WORK FOR COMMON PROSPERITY

From Our Special Representative
NEW DELHI, Aug. 15.—Two new Dominions, India and Pakistan, were born at zero hour today, ushering in political freedom to 400 million people, constituting one-fifth of the human race.

A special session of the Indian Constituent Assembly, the House assumed full powers for the administration of the Indian Dominion.

The Constituent Assembly tonight passed Pandit Nehru's resolution prescribing the Oath. All the members took the Oath then. Pandit Nehru, President of the Constituent Assembly, led the members in the Oath-taking ceremony.

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Mr. Frederick Burrows, retiring Governor of Bengal, and Mr. Rajagopalachari, Chief Minister of West Bengal, at Government House, Calcutta.

First Governor of W. Bengal

C. R. Sworn In This Morning

By a Staff Reporter
WITH the birth of the Indian Dominion this morning, Mr. C. Rajagopalachari assumed charge of the office of Governor of West Bengal at one o'clock (P.T.) this morning. Immediately afterwards Dr. P. C. Ghosh, Chief Minister, West Bengal, and the members of his Cabinet were sworn in.

The ceremony took place in the Throne Room of Government House, Calcutta, in the presence of high-ranking civil and military officials and some distinguished citizens, the whole proceedings occupying a little over an hour.

Mr. Rajagopalachari's daughter also attended.

In order that the Calcutta celebration should be complete, the usual inauguration ceremonies elsewhere in the Indian Dominion, the evening of the day.

(Continued on page 2 column 1.)

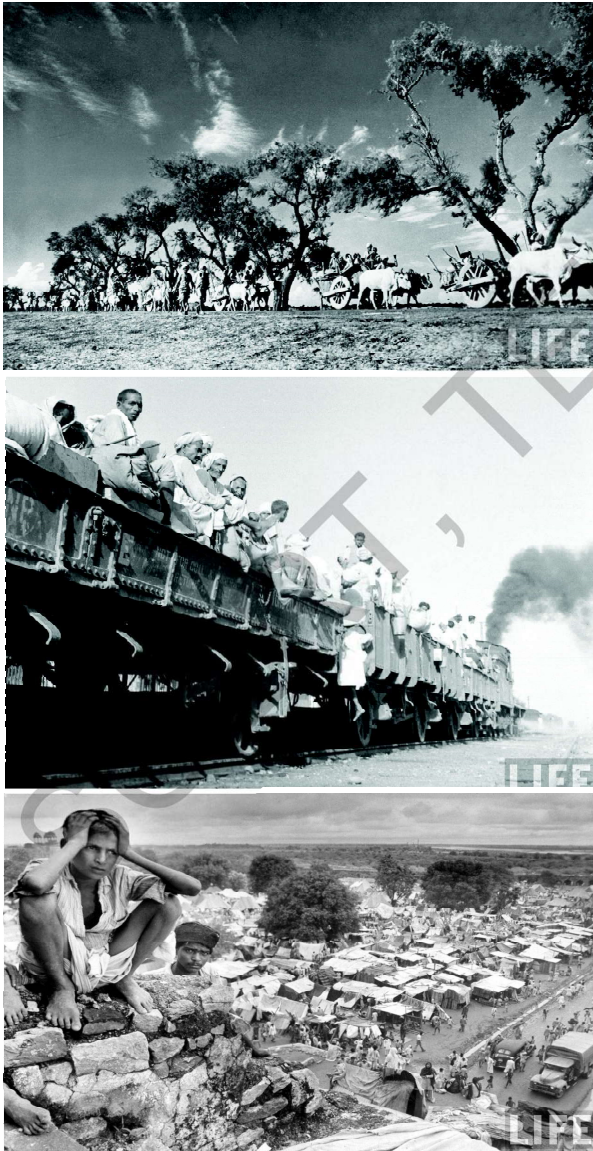
Two Holidays
Members of The Statesman Staff will participate in the two public holidays on August 15 and 16 officially announced to celebrate the birth of the two new Dominions. There will, therefore, be no issue of the paper on August 15 and 16.



Fig 14.6 : Newspaper report on Indian Independence. What different items can you identify in it? Discuss.

They killed, looted and burnt each other. Between two to five lakh people, both Muslims and Hindus, were killed. Some became refugees, lived in relief camps, and travelled on trains to find shelters. Mahatma Gandhi moved amongst the riot-hit people, in camps and hospitals. He was trying to spread the message of peace and brotherhood. This was not the freedom and Swaraj he had worked so hard to achieve. The Father of the Nation fasted and did not celebrate on the first Independence Day.

At the initiative of Gandhi and Nehru, Congress now passed a resolution on “the rights of minorities”. Congress party had never accepted the “two-nation theory”. It was forced to accept Partition against its will. It still believed that “India is a land of many religions and many races, and must remain so”. Whatever be the situation in Pakistan, India would be “a democratic secular State” where all citizens



*Fig 14.7 : Various scenes of partition.
Describe/Imagine the experiences of these migrants.*



enjoy full rights and are have equal right to get the protection of the State, irrespective of the religion to which they belong.

14.7 Assassination of Mahatma Gandhi

On 15th August, 1947, Mahatma Gandhi, father of the nation, was trying to bring peace to riot-torn Noakhali (in Bengal). He came to the capital, Delhi, only on 9th September, 1947. The old man was unhappy with the communal riots in north-western India and tried to calm the fears and anger of the people. Yet, some sections of people were annoyed with Gandhi for his role in Indian politics. They disturbed his all-religion prayer meetings many times. An unsuccessful attempt on his life was made two days before his actual assassination. It was on 28 January, 1948 that Gandhi said, "If I am to die by the bullet of a mad man, I must do so smiling. There must be no anger within me. God must be in my heart and on my lips."

Finally, less than six months after Independence, on the evening of 30th January, 1948, Gandhi was shot with three bullets while going for his all-religion prayer meeting. Before dying Gandhi said, 'Hey Ram'. His assassin, Nathuram Godse was arrested by the police then and there. He was once a member of Hindu Mahasabha and because of his actions, many became against this organisation. Consequently, on 14th February, 1948, All India Hindu Mahasabha decided to 'suspend its political work and concentrate on real organisational work' instead. A fanatic Godse had, thereby, hurt his own friends and harmed his own mission.

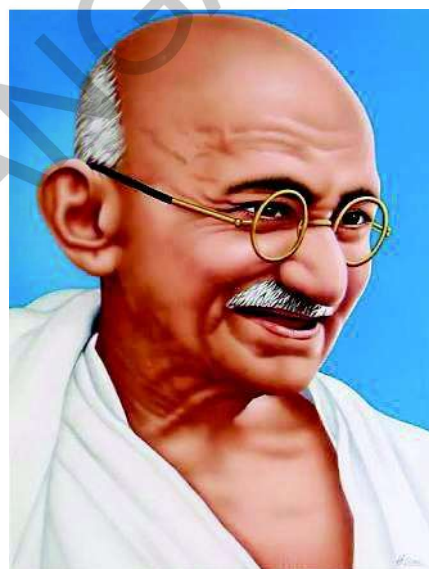


Fig 14.8 : Mahatma Gandhi

14.8 Integration of States

There were around 550 Princely states in India. These states enjoyed different levels of sovereignty but all were under British power. As the British were going to withdraw from India, these princely states were going to become independent. They were asked to decide if they wanted to join India, Pakistan or remain independent. The ordinary people of the princely states had become aware of democratic rights through participation in Praja Mandal movements. They did not want the princely families to continue to rule over them. In Travancore and Hyderabad, peasants were revolting with arms against the ruling zamindars.

The Congress supported the movements of the people of the princely states and declared that they should join India in making the new Constitution of the country. Sardar Patel was given charge of this matter in July 1947. He began discussions with the princes about the necessity to join India. He even made it clear that if they did not do so,

the army would have to be sent to complete the process of unification. By 15th August 1947, all states except Kashmir, Hyderabad and Junagadh had agreed to sign the Instrument of Accession with India. These three states were also made to join in the next two years.

The government of these princely states was taken over and the princes were given pension funds called privy-purse to meet their personal expenses. New administrative units were created by combining different territories. The first phase of this process of creating the new states of India went on till 1956. Interestingly, in 1971, the government of India abolished the privy purses and titles used by the former princely families.

The modern India that you know came into being. In 1947, it was a poor nation with low human development indicators and bad infrastructural facilities. In two centuries, colonialism had blocked the development of the country and tried to destroy the self-confidence of its people. Building a modern self-dependent and equitable nation in India was both a challenge and an opportunity.



Keywords

Dominion Status

Divide and rule

Separate electorate



Improve your learning

1. Make a table and show how different groups, and individuals in India responded to World War II. What dilemmas were faced by these groups?
2. Given the brutal manner in which particular communities like Jews and others were treated in Germany, do you think it would have been morally right to support Germany or Japan?
3. Make a list of various reasons for the Partition of the country.
4. What were the different ways in which power sharing among different communities was organised before Partition?
5. How did British colonialists practice their 'divide and rule' policy in India? How was it similar or different from what you have studied about Nigeria?
6. What were the different ways in which religion was used in politics before Partition?
7. How were workers and peasants mobilised during the last years of freedom struggle?
8. How did Partition affect the lives of ordinary people? What was the political response to mass migration following Partition?
9. Integration of various princely states into the new Indian nation was a challenging task. Discuss.
10. Locate the following in the political map of India.
a) Kashmir b) Hyderabad c) Junagarh d) Bengal e) Travancore
11. Which qualities do you like in Subhash Chandra Bose? Why.

